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Unveiled, populist provocateur talks tactics

His right-wing, AI-generated outlet skewers state's leaders, attracts criticism

By Aidan Ryan
GLOBE STAFF

For Michelle Wu's first three years as mayor, the anonymous account @AntiWuCoalition on Twitter (and then X) launched attack after attack on her, even calling on Wu to resign when she announced her third child was on the way.

Today, the author of those posts — a 36-year-old Boston software engineer — runs what he calls Mass Daily News, a right-wing, largely AI-generated website. He's attracted tens of thousands of social media followers and has fueled viral media cycles targeting City Hall and Beacon Hill.

Until now, few have known the identity of the man behind the website. Some have tried, unsuccessfully, to suss him out. The Globe combed through public records and matched the company that runs the site to Simon Pacheco, a former Florida resident who confirmed in interviews that he runs the site.

"There was clearly a substantial audience in Massachusetts that wanted a more populist, right-of-center outlet," Pacheco said. "I knew that there was a bigger opportunity than essentially just being a social media commentator."

He has tried to stay under the radar, registering Mass Daily Media LLC in Wyoming without his name. But since the site launched in July 2025, his controversial posts have gotten plenty of attention.

An April 2026 post ran with this headline: "Cash-strapped Boston partners with nonprofit to offer 'LGBTQ+ migrants' up to $500 for yoga, massages and hair salons — as hundreds of teachers face layoffs." It went viral on social media, and was picked up by the Boston Herald, New York Post, and Fox News.

In just a matter of days, the nonprofit offering the services said it would return a $7,500 grant to the City of Boston, as its leader faced death threats. Wu's office at the time said the funding was not being used as intended.

Pacheco said he runs the site alone, with no employees. He has a slight Southern twang and a polite, laid-back vibe in person, in contrast to the acidic tenor of Mass Daily News. He identifies as Latino, and says he's a first-generation Ameri-

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PHOTOS BY JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

BEAUTY AND THE BOUNTY

The bogs around Southeast Massachusetts these days are flooded, their surface a layer of bobbing red. At the Big North Bog in Carver, a worker (top) pulls a long plastic boom to corral Mullica queen cranberries in a circle. It's part of a fall tradition for workers at the A.D. Makepeace Company, the world's largest grower of cranberries. At right, berries tumble into a waiting tractor-trailer truck after being siphoned from the bog. **B3.**



Political saga reigns in race for treasurer

Goldberg battle with former cannabis regulator clouds reelection campaign

By Chris Van Buskirk
GLOBE STAFF

Sitting in a campaign adviser's office, state Treasurer Deborah Goldberg made clear that she did not want to talk about Shannon O'Brien, the state's former top cannabis regulator whom she tried to fire.

"The lawyers have told me," Goldberg said, during a conversation with a reporter, "don't say a word about Shannon O'Brien."

She then proceeded to say many.

The yearslong — and technically still-running — saga between Goldberg and her onetime appointee pushed the three-term Democrat into a series of uncomfortable headlines and a spotlight rarely focused on her relatively obscure statewide office.

Now that political drama is helping animate what would normally be an entrenched Democrat's ho-hum reelection bid and is giving Goldberg's GOP challenger, Elizabeth Dionne, unusual fuel in her attempt to do what no Republican has done in seven decades in Massachusetts. That is, defeat a Democratic incumbent for one of Massachusetts' constitutional offices.

"Do I think it made me more vulnerable? Absolutely, because it got an awful lot of press," Goldberg said of her attempt to fire O'Brien, which she

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Existing laws leave loophole for rogue AI

Legal scholars call for new statutes to manage risks

By Hiawatha Bray
GLOBE STAFF

Why isn't Sam Altman under arrest?

The cofounder and chief executive of the artificial intelligence company OpenAI is free as a bird, even though software from his company has conducted illicit break-ins of multiple computer networks, including the software development firm Hugging Face and an Australian government health-care site. These acts would be criminal if committed by a human being.

NEWS ANALYSIS

AI agents from Anthropic, Google, and Meta have committed similar acts of digital breaking-and-entering. But no one's been arrested, and so far, hardly anyone has even filed a lawsuit.

Why not? Because proving that AI creators are legally liable for their products' digital misdeeds is a difficult job under existing criminal or civil laws. Legal analysts told the Globe there's only an outside chance that a prosecution or lawsuit would succeed.

"There's attorneys general who are suggesting

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Slick back

Tuesday: Overcast, showers. High 60-65. Low 56-61.
Wednesday: Warming up. High 73-78. Low 51-56.
Sunrise: 6:55 Sunset: 6:05
Obituaries, **C9**
Comics and Weather, **D5-6**

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Massachusetts school districts are bracing for budget-busting pressures over the skyrocketing price of diesel fuel and heating oil. **B1.**

Elon Musk has funneled more than $276 million into Republican groups and his super PAC, making him the largest known donor in the midterms. **A2.**

Two American professors were awarded the Nobel Memorial Prize in Economic Sciences for research that has helped guide policies aimed at reducing economic volatility. **D1.**

Celtics coach Joe Mazzulla has sought a different view during preseason games, asking assistant coaches to take turns in his role. **C1.**

After a week of lockdowns, thousands of protesters marched in Delhi to challenge sweeping revisions of India's voter roll. **A3.**

Similar towns, diverging school districts

Test scores heading in different directions for Wakefield, Stoneham

By Marcela Rodrigues
GLOBE STAFF

WAKEFIELD – On a recent Wednesday, third-graders at Dolbeare Elementary arranged small, plastic cubes in equal rows and columns. Teacher Ashleigh Cardarelli asked them to figure out how many configurations they could make with eight and then 16 cubes.

A few miles away at Galvin Middle School, seventh-graders mixed varying amounts of water and powdered cherry mix to learn about ratios. Would a quarter teaspoon of the cherry mix taste as strong as one and a half teaspoons of the same mix?

These math lessons are part of a curriculum Wakefield Public Schools adopted soon after the COVID-19 pandemic. The teaching materials, known as Illustrative Math,

TEST SCORES, Page A10



LANE TURNER/GLOBE STAFF

Ashleigh Cardarelli, a third-grade math teacher at the Dolbeare Elementary School in Wakefield, credits the curriculum for her students' success.